

ENGLISH IN CHAPTERS

Level B2

Upper-Intermediate

Grammar made short and clear

12 chapters · 3 examples per topic · appendix of further reference

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Start

This guide turns Carmen's grammar cheat sheets into twelve short, numbered chapters for confident, professional English. Each chapter gives you the rule in plain words, three real examples — including passive, perfect and business usage — and a link to the Appendix for extra reference material drawn from the same source sheets.

How to use this guide: read the rule, study the three examples, then follow the "See Appendix" link at the end of each chapter for extra reference material pulled from the same source sheets.

1. Present Tenses (Simple, Passive, Perfect, Perfect Continuous)

Beyond the Present Simple and Continuous, B2 English uses the Present Passive to focus on the action rather than the doer, the Present Perfect for a past action with a result now, and the Present Perfect Continuous for an action continuing up to now.

Examples:

- Breakfast is eaten at 7 a.m. (Present Simple Passive)
- I have eaten already. (Present Perfect)
- I have been eating too much. (Present Perfect Continuous)

→ See Appendix 1 for more examples

2. Past Tenses (Simple, Continuous, Perfect, Passive)

The Past Perfect describes an action completed before another past action (and is used for "regrets" with "if"). The Passive forms shift the focus to what happened to the subject.

Examples:

- The apple was eaten yesterday. (Past Simple Passive)
- I had eaten before they arrived. (Past Perfect — action 1 before action 2)
- The meal was being eaten when I arrived. (Past Continuous Passive)

→ See Appendix 2 for more examples

3. Future Tenses & Conditionals

Future Passive and Future Perfect describe events done to the subject or completed by a given future point. Conditionals link a condition to a result — the Third Conditional describes a hypothetical past situation.

Examples:

- Dinner will be eaten at 8. (Future Simple Passive)
- I will have eaten by 9. (Future Perfect)
- If we had acted earlier, we would have avoided losses. (Third Conditional)

→ See Appendix 3 for more examples

4. Prepositions Before "-ing"

A preposition is always followed by the "-ing" form of a verb, never the base infinitive.

Examples:

- Mark played the piano without making any mistakes. (without + -ing)
- I passed the test by studying very hard. (by + -ing)

- Amy went to work in spite of feeling ill. (in spite of + -ing)

[→ See Appendix 4 for more examples](#)

5. Adverbs in Professional English

With a modal verb (can, must, should) or an auxiliary (will, have), the adverb goes between the two verbs — the "Sandwich Rule". Adverbs are also common in business reporting.

Examples:

- You must always check the rules. (the Sandwich Rule)
- Sales rose significantly. (business result — from "significant")
- The startup bravely deployed raw software. (adverb of manner in a business context)

[→ See Appendix 5 for more examples](#)

6. Comparison Adjectives (full system)

Beyond "-er/-est", B2 English uses "less...than" and "the least" for uncountable qualities, and "fewer...than" / "the fewest" for countable items.

Examples:

- This task is less difficult than that one. (less + adjective, uncountable)
- I have fewer books than you. (fewer + noun, countable)
- This is the most important lesson. (superlative, long adjective)

[→ See Appendix 6 for more examples](#)

7. Possessive 's vs. Noun as Adjective

Use 's when something belongs to one specific person or thing ("Whose is it?"). Use the noun as an adjective, with no 's, when it describes a general category or department ("What kind of thing is it?").

Examples:

- The employee's performance was excellent. (specific — 's)
- We review annual employee performance. (general category — no 's)
- Designers are keen on improving UX (user experience). (noun as adjective)

[→ See Appendix 7 for more examples](#)

8. Linking Words in Professional Writing

Formal linking words connect ideas across sentences in reports and emails: contrast (however), addition (furthermore) and result (consequently).

Examples:

- She ran fast; however, she missed the morning train. (However — contrast, B1)

- The text is long; furthermore, it lacks arguments. (Furthermore — addition, B2)
- Taxes went up; consequently, spending fell. (Consequently — result, B2)

→ See Appendix 8 for more examples

9. Gerunds vs. Infinitives

Use the "-ing" form when the activity itself is the subject of the sentence or follows a preposition. Use "to + verb" after verbs of intent, plan or purpose.

Examples:

- Onboarding new employees takes two weeks. (gerund as subject)
- I look forward to seeing you soon. (preposition + -ing)
- I want to play tennis. (infinitive after a verb of intent)

→ See Appendix 9 for more examples

10. Modal Verbs — Nuance & Obligation

"Need to" expresses internal/practical necessity; "have to" expresses an obligation imposed by an external rule; "might" expresses low probability.

Examples:

- We need to do this analysis. (need to — internal necessity)
- We have to follow customer requirements. (have to — external obligation)
- The supplier might be late. (might — low probability)

→ See Appendix 10 for more examples

11. Professional & Business Verbs

Business English relies on a set of precise action verbs for describing plans, processes and deliverables.

Examples:

- We need to design a modern, user-friendly landing page for the startup. (design — B1)
- The startup aims to establish a permanent presence in the Cairo business market. (establish — B2)
- The company will implement a new remote-work policy starting this January. (implement — B2)

→ See Appendix 11 for more examples

12. Word Building: Verbs → Adjectives

Many past participles (v3 forms) act as adjectives describing the state of a thing after an action — common in technical and business documentation.

Examples:

- The requested data was sent successfully. (requested — from "to request")
- Please fill in all the required fields. (required — from "to require")
- You can review the updated documentation. (updated — from "to update")

→ See Appendix 12 for more examples

Appendix — Further Reference

Extra reference material for each chapter, drawn from Carmen's source sheets (grammar summary and cheat sheets).

1. Present Tenses (Simple, Passive, Perfect, Perfect Continuous)

- Present Perfect Continuous signal words: all day, for 4 years, since 1993, how long?, the whole week.
- Present Perfect signal words: already, ever, just, never, so far, till now, up to now.

2. Past Tenses (Simple, Continuous, Perfect, Passive)

- Past Simple: focuses on finished points/events. Past Continuous: focuses on duration, background or interruption.

3. Future Tenses & Conditionals

- Also useful: Zero Conditional — "If costs increase, profits decrease." First Conditional — "If we approve the budget, the project will start."

4. Prepositions Before "-ing"

- More examples: "Thanks for helping me." / "She is afraid of flying." / "He is great at cooking."

5. Adverbs in Professional English

- More business adverbs: efficiently, successfully, reliably, consistently, urgently.

6. Comparison Adjectives (full system)

- Also: "This is the least useful tool" / "She has the fewest mistakes."

7. Possessive 's vs. Noun as Adjective

- Rule of thumb: if you can say "of the [specific thing]", use 's; if you can say "for/related to [things]", don't.

8. Linking Words in Professional Writing

- More formal connectors: despite, nevertheless, as a result, for that reason, all things considered.

9. Gerunds vs. Infinitives

- Compare: "I look forward to seeing you" (verb) vs. "I look forward to the party" (noun after "to").

10. Modal Verbs — Nuance & Obligation

- Also: "Could you help me?" (could — polite request) / "It may rain tomorrow." (may — formal possibility).

11. Professional & Business Verbs

- Related nouns/verbs pair: "Always keep a backup of your files" (noun) / "Don't forget to backup your data weekly" (verb).

12. Word Building: Verbs → Adjectives

- More: confirmed (from "to confirm"), encrypted (from "to encrypt"), fixed (from "to fix"), automated (from "to automate").